DHURANDHARMANIA

₹790+ CRORE
Domestic box office collections of *Dhurandhar*, crossing the benchmark of a 100-day theatrical run

₹1,000+ CRORE
Dhurandhar: The Revenge beat its predecessor to become the biggest Hindi film of all time and the first Hindi film to hit the Rs 1,000 crore mark domestically

$28.1 MILLION
Dhurandhar: The Revenge is the first Indian film to hit the mark in the United States. It beat *Bahubali: The Conclusion*'s record of $20 million

₹61-62 CRORE
Collections of the dubbed versions of *Dhurandhar: The Revenge*

3+ CRORE FOOTFALLS
Achieved by *Dhurandhar: The Revenge*, joining *Gadar 2*, *Jawan*, *Stree 2*, *Chhaava* and *Dhurandhar* as the sixth original Hindi film to enter the select club post-pandemic

All figures are NET and domestic collections. Credit: Box Office India and boxofficemojo.com

fictional narrative to bolster Hamza's struggle. The spy himself often stays in the shadows, ceding narrative space to Pakistani gangsters.

The film's attention to detail has also earned its fair share of fans, unusual for a Bollywood film, with the duology inspiring a unique online hashtag: #peakdetailing. Fans have taken to pinpointing how Sanyal doesn't leave his cigarette stub in a Dubai hotel lest he leave his DNA behind, or how Jaskirat Singh Rangi (undercover as Hamza) is also the name of a character in *Uri*, a testament to Dhar's deep world-building. Instagram has introduced a font inspired by the title's typography. Other touches, like the film's use of chapters to break down the narrative, are reminiscent of Quentin Tarantino's Kill Bill films, an aspect particularly favoured by Rai. Dhar has "incorporated global influences and indigenised them", says Swapnil Rai, professor of Media Studies at the University of Michigan and author of *Networked Bollywood*.

The music, too, plays a big role in the films' popularity. Your patriotic side, of course, roots for Hamza as he shoots down Karachi-based terrorists, but the depiction of Akshaye Khanna's Rahman Dakait and Sanjay Dutt's Aslam Chaudhary to the tune of reimagined classics like 'Hawa Hawa', 'Monica, O My Darling', 'Tama Tama Loge' and 'Yeh Ishq Ishq' gets you tapping your feet, too. There's no escaping Flipperachi's track 'FA9LA' on social media, now the internet's go-to swag anthem. Composer Shashwat Sachdev's soundtrack thrives on nostalgia-tripping. Says Rai, "It is a very creative sampling of well-known favourites, recasting them into a global, energetic, rap-driven aural experience. It works across multiple generations, with millennials and Gen Z alike enamoured of this hybrid blend."



WORRYING PRECEDENT?

But the duology isn't without its critics. Multiple clips of Prime Minister Narendra Modi in Part 2, and Pakistani characters referring to him as a "chaiwala" who has made their lives miserable, have attracted accusations of Dhar serving a political agenda. As has the incorporation of the 2016 demonetisation exercise into the narrative. However, the films have become such a lightning rod of political sentiment that any criticism invites accusations of being anti-national. According to Shohini Ghosh, professor at the AJK Mass Communication Research Centre, Jamia Milia Islamia, Delhi, "A large majority of audiences don't read films ideologically but enjoy the affective experience they provide." Rai feels that the film is "a reflection of contemporary nationalist sentiment in the country", and says that while it's not "the most ideologically nuanced film, [it's] not propaganda either. It is not a mouthpiece of the state, nor does it intend to 'educate'. The motive, rather, is to entertain." She equates the films to Frederick Forsyth's novels. "The narrative is so rooted in historical facts that the fiction that is constructed becomes absolutely compelling," she says. But she does have a problem with films like *Dhurandhar* mainstreaming gory violence. "It is concerning," she says, "because if films do reflect national sentiment, what does the affinity for violence convey in terms of major shifts in the sociocultural fabric?"

Be that as it may, the filmmaking fraternity is in awe of Dhar. "I believe [he] has completely and single-handedly changed the future of Indian cinema," wrote Ram Gopal Varma in a long social media post. "He doesn't direct scenes here... he engineers the states of minds of both the characters and us audience. This is a film that refuses